These features typically rely on specialized domain knowledge and skills, so it makes sense to build them with in-house resources. Features in this category need to be highly innovative in order to gain and maintain a competitive advantage.

3.8.2 Parity features

A *parity* feature is mission critical but doesn't provide much market differentiation. These are features that aren't particularly glamorous but are required for the product to be viable. All your competitors provide these features, and it's expected that you do too. An example of a parity feature might be online payment with credit cards for an e-commerce site, or the ability to view old account statements for an online retail bank.

As the name suggests, you need to implement these features to provide roughly the same level of service as is found in competing products. If you do any less than that, you'll put your organization at a competitive disadvantage. But it would be wasteful to spend too much effort on these features, as the return on investment will be marginal.

3.8.3 Partner features

Partner features are not mission critical but can still differentiate your product from the competition. These features are not usually part of the core expertise of your organization, so it might be inefficient to build up this expertise for one project. In this case, it makes sense to team up with a partner who is more specialized in this area.

3.8.4 Minimum impact

Some features are neither mission critical nor market differentiating. You should try to spend as little time and effort as possible on features in this category. These low-value features might be a good candidate for outsourcing.

3.9 Summary

In this chapter we discussed Feature Injection and various related concepts. You learned about the following:

- Identifying and understanding the fundamental business goals behind the applications you build makes it much easier to design and build valuable features.
- Feature Injection is a technique that tries to identify the business value that an application is expected to deliver, and to identify the essential features that will deliver this value.
- Impact Mapping enables you to visualize the relationships between stakeholders, capabilities, features, and business goals.
- The Purpose-Based Alignment Model helps you decide how much effort to put into the different features you decide to implement.

In the next chapter, we'll take these ideas further and look at how you can discover the features and scenarios most likely to deliver value. We'll also look at how you can better manage your lack of knowledge, and understand and prioritize the features you build and deliver, using concepts such as Deliberate Discovery and Real Options.